Philosophy Lectures · outside the curriculum; it falls within History of Philosophy (2nd year) and Philosophy (1st year) · If God is dead, what is left? · Class 2 of 8 · With Javier

How the chair was emptied

Class video: https://youtu.be/unoQ5TY11e8
The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

The texts, in full

The lecture reads or retells passages from seven texts: two by René Descartes, one by Zhuangzi, three by Immanuel Kant and one by Mary Wollstonecraft. Here they are in full, or in a somewhat longer passage, in our translation and in their original language. They are for reading slowly, without hurry and without questions: it is what the lecture had no time to read.

About the translation. The translations are our own, made from the original of each text and checked word for word against it. Those of Descartes, Zhuangzi, Kant's *Groundwork* and his *Critique of Practical Reason* were also checked against a classic public-domain English translation: John Veitch's, Herbert Giles's (1889) and Thomas Kingsmill Abbott's. Mary Wollstonecraft wrote in English, so hers is the original. They aim to be literal rather than elegant. Four notes: - **«je pense, donc je suis»** says, literally, "I think, therefore I am", which is also how it is always said in English. In Spanish the usual form is «pienso, luego existo» ("I think, therefore I exist"), and that is what the lecture says. - **«la prévention»** is "prevention" in its old sense: judging ahead of time, prejudice. The lecture puts it in today's words: «las prisas y los prejuicios», "haste and prejudice". - **«Unmündigkeit»** is legal minority: living under a guardian, like a minor, unable to decide for oneself. - **«niemals bloß als Mittel brauchst»** is, literally, "never merely use as a means". A few pages later, Kant says the same with «behandeln», "treat", which is how the lecture puts it. That «bloß», "merely", is the word that, as the lecture warns, so often gets lost in quotations.

Descartes, Discourse on the Method, part II: the four rules (1637)

This is the part that begins in the stove-heated room, in the winter of 1619. Descartes explains why he settled on just four rules for thinking. The lecture reads the first.

And as a multitude of laws often provides excuses for vices, so that a state is much better ruled when it has very few and they are very strictly observed there, so, instead of the great number of precepts of which logic is composed, I believed that the four following would be enough for me, provided I took a firm and constant resolution not to fail to observe them even once.

The first was never to accept anything as true unless I knew with evidence that it was so; that is to say, carefully to avoid precipitation and prevention, and to include nothing more in my judgements than what presented itself to my mind so clearly and so distinctly that I had no occasion to call it into doubt.

The second, to divide each of the difficulties I examined into as many parts as could be done and as would be needed to solve them better.

The third, to conduct my thoughts in order, beginning with the simplest objects and the easiest to know, so as to climb little by little, as if by steps, up to the knowledge of the most composite; and even assuming an order among those which do not naturally precede one another.

And the last, to make everywhere enumerations so complete and reviews so general that I would be sure of leaving nothing out.

In French (1637)

In the spelling of the first edition: *u* sometimes stands for *v* (*receuoir*, today *recevoir*) and *i* for *j* (*iamais*, today *jamais*). We have only replaced the long *s* (ſ) with the modern one.

> Et comme la multitude des loix fournist souuent des excuses aux vices; en sorte qu'vn estat est bien mieux reiglé, lorsque n'en ayant que fort peu, elles y sont fort estroitement obseruées: Ainsi au lieu de ce grand nombre de preceptes dont la Logique est composée, ie creu que i'aurois assez des quatre suiuans, pourvû que ie prisse vne ferme & constante resolution de ne manquer pas vne seule fois a les obseruer.
>
> Le premier estoit de ne receuoir iamais aucune chose pour vraye que ie ne la connusse euidemment estre telle: c'est à dire, d'euiter soigneusement la Precipitation, & la Preuention; & de ne comprendre rien de plus en mes iugemens, que ce qui se presenteroit si clairement & si distinctement a mon esprit, que ie n'eusse aucune occasion de le mettre en doute.
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> Le second, de diuiser chascune des difficultez que i'examinerois en autant de parcelles qu'il se pourroit, & qu'il seroit requis pour les mieux resoudre.

> Le troisiesme de conduire par ordre mes pensées, en commenceant par les obiets les plus simples, & les plus aysez a connoistre, pour monter peu a peu comme par degrez iusques a la connoissance des plus composez: Et supposant mesme de l'ordre entre ceux qui ne se precedent point naturellement les vns les autres.
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> Et le dernier de faire partout des denombremens si entiers, & des reueuës si generales, que ie fusse assuré de ne rien omettre.

Descartes, Discourse on the Method, part IV: «je pense, donc je suis» (1637)

This is the beginning of part four. Descartes tells how he doubted everything until he found something he could not doubt.

I do not know whether I ought to tell you about the first meditations I made there, for they are so metaphysical and so uncommon that they will perhaps not be to everyone's taste. And yet, so that one may judge whether the foundations I have taken are firm enough, I find myself in some way compelled to speak of them. I had long since noticed that, in matters of conduct, it is sometimes necessary to follow opinions one knows to be very uncertain just as if they were indubitable, as has been said above; but because I then wished to devote myself solely to the search for truth, I thought I had to do the very opposite, and reject as absolutely false everything in which I could imagine the least doubt, in order to see whether, after that, there would not remain something in my belief that was entirely indubitable. Thus, because our senses sometimes deceive us, I chose to suppose that there was nothing that was such as they make us imagine it. And because there are men who make mistakes in reasoning, even about the simplest matters of geometry, and commit paralogisms (false reasonings) in them, judging that I was as liable to err as anyone else, I rejected as false all the reasons I had previously taken for demonstrations. And finally, considering that all the very same thoughts we have when awake can also come to us when we are asleep, without any of them being true at that time, I resolved to pretend that all the things that had ever entered my mind were no more true than the illusions of my dreams. But immediately afterwards I noticed that, while I wanted to think in this way that everything was false, it was necessary that I, who was thinking it, be something. And noticing that this truth, *I think, therefore I am*, was so firm and so certain that all the most extravagant suppositions of the sceptics were not capable of shaking it, I judged that I could accept it without scruple as the first principle of the philosophy I was seeking.

In French (1637)

Besides replacing the long *s*, we have expanded three printer's abbreviations and corrected one misprint: the 1637 edition has «le mes songes» for «de mes songes».

> Ie ne sçay si ie doy vous entretenir des premieres meditations que i'y ay faites, car elles sont si Metaphysiques & si peu communes, qu'elles ne seront peutestre pas au goust de tout le monde: Et toutefois affin qu'on puisse iuger si les fondemens que i'ay pris sont assez fermes,

ie me trouue en quelque façon contraint d'en parler. I'auois dés long tems remarqué que pour les meurs il est besoin quelquefois de suiure des opinions qu'on sçait estre fort incertaines, tout de mesme que si elles estoient indubitables, ainsi qu'il a esté dit cy dessus: mais pourcequ'alors ie desirois vacquer seulement a la recherche de la verité, ie pensay qu'il faloit que ie fisse tout le contraire, & que ie reiettasse comme absolument faux tout ce en quoy ie pourrois imaginer le moindre doute, affin de voir s'il ne resteroit point aprés cela quelque chose en ma creance qui fust entierement indubitable. Ainsi a cause que nos sens nous trompent quelquefois, ie voulû supposer qu'il n'y auoit aucune chose qui fust telle qu'ils nous la font imaginer: Et pourcequ'il y a des hommes qui se méprenent en raisonnant, mesme touchant les plus simples matieres de Geometrie, & y font des Paralogismes, iugeant que i'estois suiet a faillir autant qu'aucun autre, ie reiettay comme fausses toutes les raisons que i'auois prises auparauant pour Demonstrations: Et enfin considerant que toutes les mesmes pensées que nous auons estant esueillez, nous peuuent aussy venir quand nous dormons sans qu'il y en ait aucune pour lors qui soit vraye, ie me resolu de feindre que toutes les choses qui m'estoient iamais entrées en l'esprit n'estoient non plus vrayes que les illusions de mes songes. Mais aussytost aprés ie pris garde, que pendant que ie voulois ainsi penser que tout estoit faux, il falloit necessairement que moy qui le pensois fusse quelque chose: Et remarquant que cete verité, *ie pense, donc ie suis*, estoit si ferme & si assurée que toutes les plus extrauagantes suppositions des Sceptiques n'estoient pas capables de l'esbransler, ie iugay que ie pouuois la receuoir sans scrupule pour le premier principe de la Philosophie que ie cherchois.

Zhuangzi, chapter 2: the butterfly dream

Zhuangzi lived in China in the fourth century BC. This story closes the second chapter of the book that bears his name. **Zhuang Zhou** is his name: Zhuangzi means "Master Zhuang".

Once, Zhuang Zhou dreamt he was a butterfly, a butterfly fluttering about: how happy it was, how free to do as it pleased! It did not know it was Zhou. Suddenly he woke up, and he was Zhou, in the flesh. He did not know whether he was Zhou who had dreamt he was a butterfly, or a butterfly dreaming it was Zhou. Between Zhou and a butterfly there must necessarily be a difference. This is what is called the transformation of things.

The transformation of things is one of Zhuangzi's ideas: everything keeps passing from one form into another, and so do we.

In classical Chinese

昔者莊周夢爲胡蝶，栩栩然胡蝶也，自喻適志與，不知周也。俄然覺，則蘧蘧然周也。不知周之夢爲胡蝶與？胡蝶之夢爲周與？周與胡蝶，則必有分矣，此之謂物化。

Kant, "An answer to the question: What is Enlightenment?" (1784)

Kant published it in a Berlin journal, the *Berlinische Monatsschrift*, in December 1784. These are its first two paragraphs.

Enlightenment is the human being's way out of his minority, for which he himself is to blame. Minority is the inability to make use of one's understanding without the guidance of another. One is to blame for this minority oneself when its cause lies not in a lack of understanding, but in a lack of resolution and courage to make use of it without the guidance of another. *Sapere aude!* ("Dare to know!", words of the Latin poet Horace). Have the courage to make use of your own understanding!: that, then, is the motto of the Enlightenment.

Laziness and cowardice are the reasons why so great a part of humankind, after nature has long since set them free from the guidance of others (*naturaliter majorennes*, of age by nature), nevertheless gladly remain minors all their lives; and why it is so easy for others to set themselves up as their guardians. It is so comfortable to be a minor. If I have a book that has understanding for me, a spiritual director who has a conscience for me, a doctor who judges my diet for me, and so on, then I need not trouble myself at all. I have no need to think, as long as I can pay; others will take the tiresome business upon themselves for me. That by far the greater part of humankind (including the entire fair sex) should consider the step to majority not only troublesome but also very dangerous: that is taken care of by those guardians who have so very kindly taken the supervision of them upon themselves. Having first made their livestock stupid, and carefully prevented these placid creatures from daring to take a single step outside the baby walker in which they shut them, they then show them the danger that threatens them if they try to walk alone. Now this danger is not really so great, for after falling a few times they would in the end learn to walk; but an example of this kind makes one timid, and usually scares one off from any further attempt.

In German (1784)

> Aufklärung ist der Ausgang des Menschen aus seiner selbst verschuldeten Unmündigkeit. Unmündigkeit ist das Unvermögen, sich seines Verstandes ohne Leitung eines anderen zu bedienen. Selbstverschuldet ist diese Unmündigkeit, wenn die Ursache derselben nicht am Mangel des Verstandes, sondern der Entschließung und des Muthes liegt, sich seiner ohne Leitung eines andern zu bedienen. Sapere aude! Habe Muth dich deines eigenen Verstandes zu bedienen! ist also der Wahlspruch der Aufklärung.
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> Faulheit und Feigheit sind die Ursachen, warum ein so großer Theil der Menschen, nachdem sie die Natur längst von fremder Leitung frei gesprochen (naturaliter majorennes), dennoch gerne Zeitlebens unmündig bleiben; und warum es Anderen so leicht wird, sich zu deren Vormündern aufzuwerfen. Es ist so bequem, unmündig zu sein. Habe ich ein Buch, das für mich Verstand hat, einen Seelsorger, der für mich Gewissen hat, einen Arzt der für mich die Diät beurtheilt, u. s. w. so brauche ich mich ja nicht selbst zu bemühen. Ich habe nicht nöthig

zu denken, wenn ich nur bezahlen kann; andere werden das verdrießliche Geschäft schon für mich übernehmen. Daß der bei weitem größte Theil der Menschen (darunter das ganze schöne Geschlecht) den Schritt zur Mündigkeit, außer dem daß er beschwerlich ist, auch für sehr gefährlich halte: dafür sorgen schon jene Vormünder, die die Oberaufsicht über sie gütigst auf sich genommen haben. Nachdem sie ihr Hausvieh zuerst dumm gemacht haben, und sorgfältig verhüteten, daß diese ruhigen Geschöpfe ja keinen Schritt außer dem Gängelwagen, darin sie sie einsperreten, wagen durften; so zeigen sie ihnen nachher die Gefahr, die ihnen drohet, wenn sie es versuchen allein zu gehen. Nun ist diese Gefahr zwar eben so groß nicht, denn sie würden durch einigemahl Fallen wohl endlich gehen lernen; allein ein Beispiel von der Art macht doch schüchtern, und schrekt gemeiniglich von allen ferneren Versuchen ab.

Kant, Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals (1785)

Three passages from the second section: the formula of humanity, price and dignity, and autonomy. The "kingdom of ends" is, for Kant, the union of all rational beings under common laws: an ideal.

If, then, there is to be a supreme practical principle and, with respect to the human will, a categorical imperative, it must be one that, from the representation of what is necessarily an end for everyone because it is an end in itself, constitutes an objective principle of the will, and can therefore serve as a universal practical law. The ground of this principle is: rational nature exists as an end in itself. The human being necessarily represents his own existence in this way; to that extent, then, it is a subjective principle of human actions. But every other rational being also represents its existence in this way, on just the same rational ground that also holds for me; so it is at the same time an objective principle, from which, as a supreme practical ground, all laws of the will must be able to be derived. The practical imperative will therefore be the following: act in such a way that you use humanity, both in your own person and in the person of every other, always at the same time as an end, never merely as a means. We shall see whether this can be carried out.

[...]

In the kingdom of ends everything has either a price or a dignity. In place of what has a price, something else can also be put as its equivalent; what, on the other hand, is raised above all price, and therefore admits of no equivalent, has a dignity.

What relates to general human inclinations and needs has a market price; what, even without presupposing a need, accords with a certain taste, that is, with a delight in the mere purposeless play of the powers of our mind, has an affective price; but what constitutes the only condition under which something can be an end in itself has not merely a relative worth, that is, a price, but an inner worth, that is, dignity.

Now morality is the only condition under which a rational being can be an end in itself, because only through it is it possible to be a lawgiving member in the kingdom of ends. Thus morality, and humanity in so far as it is capable of morality, is that which alone has dignity.

[…]

Autonomy is therefore the ground of the dignity of human nature and of every rational nature.

In German (1785, in the Academy edition)

> Wenn es denn also ein oberstes praktisches Princip und in Ansehung des menschlichen Willens einen kategorischen Imperativ geben soll, so muß es ein solches sein, das aus der Vorstellung dessen, was nothwendig für jedermann Zweck ist, weil es Zweck an sich selbst ist, ein objectives Princip des Willens ausmacht, mithin zum allgemeinen praktischen Gesetz dienen kann. Der Grund dieses Princips ist: die vernünftige Natur existirt als Zweck an sich selbst. So stellt sich nothwendig der Mensch sein eignes Dasein vor; so fern ist es also ein subjectives Princip menschlicher Handlungen. So stellt sich aber auch jedes andere vernünftige Wesen sein Dasein zufolge eben desselben Vernunftgrundes, der auch für mich gilt, vor; also ist es zugleich ein objectives Princip, woraus als einem obersten praktischen Grunde alle Gesetze des Willens müssen abgeleitet werden können. Der praktische Imperativ wird also folgender sein: Handle so, daß du die Menschheit sowohl in deiner Person, als in der Person eines jeden andern jederzeit zugleich als Zweck, niemals bloß als Mittel brauchst. Wir wollen sehen, ob sich dieses bewerkstelligen lasse.
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> […]
>
> Im Reiche der Zwecke hat alles entweder einen Preis, oder eine Würde. Was einen Preis hat, an dessen Stelle kann auch etwas anderes als Äquivalent gesetzt werden; was dagegen über allen Preis erhaben ist, mithin kein Äquivalent verstattet, das hat eine Würde.
>
> Was sich auf die allgemeinen menschlichen Neigungen und Bedürfnisse bezieht, hat einen Marktpreis; das, was, auch ohne ein Bedürfniß vorauszusetzen, einem gewissen Geschmacke, d. i. einem Wohlgefallen am bloßen zwecklosen Spiel unserer Gemüthskräfte, gemäß ist, einen Affectionspreis; das aber, was die Bedingung ausmacht, unter der allein etwas Zweck an sich selbst sein kann, hat nicht bloß einen relativen Werth, d. i. einen Preis, sondern einen innern Werth, d. i. Würde.
>
> Nun ist Moralität die Bedingung, unter der allein ein vernünftiges Wesen Zweck an sich selbst sein kann, weil nur durch sie es möglich ist, ein gesetzgebend Glied im Reiche der Zwecke zu sein. Also ist Sittlichkeit und die Menschheit, so fern sie derselben fähig ist, dasjenige, was allein Würde hat.
>
> […]
>
> Autonomie ist also der Grund der Würde der menschlichen und jeder vernünftigen Natur.

Kant, Critique of Practical Reason, conclusion (1788)

These are the first lines of the book's conclusion. The lecture reads the first sentence, shortened.

Two things fill the mind with ever new and increasing admiration and reverence, the more often and the more steadily reflection occupies itself with them: the starry heavens above me and the moral law within me. I need not search for them, nor merely conjecture them, as though they were veiled in darkness, or beyond all experience, outside my horizon: I see them before me and connect them directly with the consciousness of my existence.

In German (1788, in the Academy edition)

> Zwei Dinge erfüllen das Gemüth mit immer neuer und zunehmender Bewunderung und Ehrfurcht, je öfter und anhaltender sich das Nachdenken damit beschäftigt: der bestirnte Himmel über mir und das moralische Gesetz in mir. Beide darf ich nicht als in Dunkelheiten verhüllt, oder im Überschwenglichen, außer meinem Gesichtskreise suchen und blos vermuthen; ich sehe sie vor mir und verknüpfe sie unmittelbar mit dem Bewußtsein meiner Existenz.

Mary Wollstonecraft, A Vindication of the Rights of Woman, chapter IV (1792)

Wollstonecraft writes against those who, like Rousseau, wanted to educate women to please men. In this paragraph she answers him.

> I am fully persuaded that we should hear of none of these infantile airs, if girls were allowed to take sufficient exercise, and not confined in close rooms till their muscles are relaxed, and their powers of digestion destroyed. To carry the remark still further, if fear in girls, instead of being cherished, perhaps, created, was treated in the same manner as cowardice in boys, we should quickly see women with more dignified aspects. It is true, they could not then with equal propriety be termed the sweet flowers that smile in the walk of man; but they would be more respectable members of society, and discharge the important duties of life by the light of their own reason. 'Educate women like men,' says Rousseau, 'and the more they resemble our sex the less power will they have over us.' This is the very point I aim at. I do not wish them to have power over men; but over themselves.

Rousseau's sentence is quoted by Wollstonecraft in summary. In *Emile* (1762), book V, he says: "Come! Make up your minds to bring them up like men: the men will gladly consent to it! The more they want to resemble them, the less they will govern them; and that is when the men will truly be the masters."

Eh ! prenez le parti de les élever comme des hommes ; ils y consentiront de bon cœur ! Plus elles voudront leur ressembler, moins elles les gouverneront ; & c'est alors qu'ils seront vraiment les maîtres.

Where they come from

- **Descartes.** *Discours de la méthode*, Leiden: Ian Maire, 1637, pp. 19–20 (part II) and 32–33 (part IV). The first edition, scanned (archive.org, public domain): https://archive.org/details/discoursdelamet00desca . The same text in the Adam and Tannery edition (AT VI 18–19 and 31–32), on Wikisource: https://fr.wikisource.org/wiki/Discours_de_la_m%C3%A9thode/%C3%89dition_Adam_et_Tannery . John Veitch's English translation (Project Gutenberg, public domain): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/59

- **Zhuangzi.** Chapter 2, "Qiwu lun" (齊物論), on Chinese Wikisource: https://zh.wikisource.org/wiki/%E8%8E%8A%E5%AD%90/%E9%BD%8A%E7%89%A9%E8%AB%96 . Herbert A. Giles's English translation, *Chuang Tzŭ: Mystic, Moralist, and Social Reformer*, London: Bernard Quaritch, 1889 (Project Gutenberg, public domain): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/59709

- **What is Enlightenment?** «Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?», *Berlinische Monatsschrift*, December 1784, pp. 481–482 (AA VIII 35–36). On German Wikisource: https://de.wikisource.org/wiki/Beantwortung_der_Frage:_Was_ist_Aufkl%C3%A4rung%3F . The journal, scanned and transcribed in the Deutsches Textarchiv: https://www.deutschestextarchiv.de/book/show/kant_aufklaerung_1784 . Horace's line, *Epistles*, I, 2, 40 («Dimidium facti, qui coepit, habet; sapere aude, incipe»: who has begun has half the deed done; dare to know, begin), in The Latin Library: https://www.thelatinlibrary.com/horace/epist1.shtml

- **Groundwork.** *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*, Riga: Johann Friedrich Hartknoch, 1785. The German text is that of the Berlin Academy edition, the standard one (AA IV 428–429, 434–435 and 436), on korpora.org: https://korpora.org/kant/aa04/429.html , https://korpora.org/kant/aa04/434.html and https://korpora.org/kant/aa04/436.html . Thomas Kingsmill Abbott's English translation (Project Gutenberg, public domain): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5682

- **Critique of Practical Reason.** *Critik der practischen Vernunft*, Riga: Johann Friedrich Hartknoch, 1788, conclusion («Beschluß»), pp. 288–289 (AA V 161–162). The Academy edition, on korpora.org: https://korpora.org/kant/aa05/161.html . The first edition, in the Deutsches Textarchiv: https://www.deutschestextarchiv.de/book/show/kant_pvernunft_1788 . Abbott's English translation (Project Gutenberg, public domain): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/5683

- **Wollstonecraft.** *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*, 1792, chapter IV. The Boston edition (Thomas and Andrews, 1792), pp. 111–112, scanned and transcribed on Wikisource: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/A_Vindication_of_the_Rights_of_Woman/Chapter_IV . The same passage on Project Gutenberg (ebook 3420, from a later edition): https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3420 . Rousseau, *Émile*, book V, in the 1782 edition, on Wikisource: https://fr.wikisource.org/wiki/%C3%89mile,_ou_De_l%E2%80%99%C3%A9ducation/%C3%89dition_1782/Livre_V

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